PROJECT REPORT

DES: Data Encryption Standard

16-Round vs 24-Round Comparative Analysis

Prepared by:

Haleema Abid(245053)

Jalisha Eman(245113)

Samreen Shoukat(245077)

Hamna Saleem(245047)

Submitted to: Mam Kashaf Javed

Department of Computer Science

Air University Aerospace and Aviation Campus, Kamra

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Abstract

This report presents a comparative analysis of the Data Encryption Standard (DES) algorithm in its original 16-round form against a modified 24-round implementation. The analysis covers time complexity, space complexity, security improvements, and real-world performance implications, based on actual C++ implementations of both versions.

Key Finding:

- Both versions maintain O(1) time and space complexity per 64-bit block.
- The 24-round version is approximately 2.4x slower per block (~14,040 vs ~5,816 operations).
- The 24-round variant offers improved resistance to differential and linear cryptanalysis.
- Neither version addresses DES's fundamental weakness: its 56-bit key size.

1. Introduction

The Data Encryption Standard (DES) was developed in the 1970s and became a globally adopted symmetric encryption standard. It operates on 64-bit data blocks using a 56-bit key and applies a series of permutations and substitutions across 16 Feistel rounds.

This project aims to:

- Analyze time and space complexity of standard DES (16 rounds).
- Implement a modified version with 24 rounds to increase security.
- Compare complexity and performance between both versions.
- Provide a security assessment and practical recommendations.

2. DES Algorithm Overview

DES encrypts 64-bit plaintext blocks using a 56-bit key through a series of Feistel rounds. Each round involves an expansion permutation, XOR with a subkey, substitution through S-boxes, and a final permutation. An initial permutation (IP) and final permutation (FP) wrap the process.

2.1.Core Operations

Operation	Purpose	Bit Size
Initial Permutation (IP)	Reorders input bits	64 bits
Key Expansion (PC1/PC2)	Generates subkeys per round	56 → 48 bits
E-Expansion	Expands R half for XOR	32 → 48 bits
S-Box Substitution	Non-linear transformation (8 boxes)	48 → 32 bits
P-Permutation	Diffusion after S-boxes	32 bits
Final Permutation (FP)	Inverse of IP	64 bits

3. Time Complexity Analysis

3.1 Original DES — 16 Rounds

Each DES operation works on fixed-size data (64-bit blocks), meaning all operations are bounded by constants. This gives O(1) time complexity per block.

Phase	Operation Count	Complexity
Key Generation (16 rounds)	1,720 operations	O(1)
Round Function f(R,K) × 16	~3,456 operations	O(1)
IP + FP + Split/Combine	~640 operations	O(1)
Total per block	~5,816 operations	O(1)

For N blocks: T(N) = O(N) — each block takes the same constant time.

3.2 Modified DES — 24 Rounds

Extending to 24 rounds increases the number of iterations in both key generation and the main encryption loop. Block and key sizes remain unchanged, so complexity class stays O(1) per block.

Phase	Operation Count	Complexity
Key Generation (24 rounds)	5,144 operations	O(1)
Round Function f(R,K) × 24	~6,336 operations	O(1)
IP + FP + Split/Combine	~640 operations	O(1)
Total per block	~14,040 operations	O(1)

3.3 Time Complexity Comparison

Metric	16 Rounds	24 Rounds	Change
Key generation	1,720 ops	5,144 ops	+199%
Per round cost	~248 ops	~264 ops	+6%
Total per block	~5,816 ops	~14,040 ops	+141%
Big-O Complexity	O(1)	O(1)	No change

Conclusion: 24-round DES is approximately 2.4x slower per block. Complexity class is unchanged.

4. Space Complexity Analysis

4.1 Original DES — 16 Rounds

Memory Type	Contents	Size	Complexity
Global Tables	IP, FP, E, P, PC1, PC2, SBOX, subkeys[16]	~4,128 B	O(1)
Stack Memory	All local variables (max depth)	~863 B	O(1)
Total		~6.4 KB	O(1)

4.2 Modified DES — 24 Rounds

Memory Type	16 Rounds	24 Rounds	Difference
Global Tables	~4,128 B	~4,544 B	+416 B
Stack Memory	~863 B	~7,384 B	+6,521 B
Total	~6.4 KB	~17 KB	+166%
Complexity	O(1)	O(1)	No change

Both versions use constant memory regardless of input size. The 24-round version uses ~17 KB vs ~6.4 KB, driven mainly by larger subkey arrays and deeper stack usage.

5. Security Analysis

5.1 Attack Resistance Comparison

Attack Type	16 Rounds	24 Rounds	Result
Brute Force	2^56 key tries	2^56 key tries	No change
Differential Cryptanalysis	Needs ~2^47 pairs	Needs more pairs	Improved
Linear Cryptanalysis	Needs ~2^43 msgs	Needs more msgs	Improved
Avalanche Effect	Achieved by round 6	Achieved by round 6	Same

Key Insight: The 56-bit key remains the critical vulnerability. Both versions are broken by modern brute-force attacks in practice (DES was deprecated in 2001 and replaced by AES).

5.2 Security Summary

- Brute force resistance is identical — the key size is unchanged at 56 bits.
- 24 rounds provides marginally better resistance to differential and linear cryptanalysis.
- The avalanche effect is achieved by round 6 in both versions — extra rounds add diminishing returns.
- For modern applications, DES (in any form) should not be used; AES-128/256 is recommended.

6. Overall Comparison Summary

Aspect	16 Rounds (Original)	24 Rounds (Modified)
Time per block	~5,800 operations	~14,000 operations
Execution speed	Baseline	~2.4x slower
Memory usage	~6.4 KB	~17 KB
Time complexity	O(1) per block	O(1) per block
Space complexity	O(1)	O(1)
Key size	56 bits	56 bits
Block size	64 bits	64 bits
Diff. cryptanalysis	Moderate	Better
Linear cryptanalysis	Moderate	Better
Overall security	Weak (deprecated)	Slightly better, still weak

7. Conclusion

This project analyzed the Data Encryption Standard in its original 16-round form and a modified 24-round variant. Both versions maintain O(1) time and space complexity per block, as all operations are performed on fixed-size 64-bit data.

The key findings are:

- **Time complexity:** O(1) per block for both; the 24-round version costs ~2.4x more operations.
- **Space complexity:** O(1) for both; 24-round uses ~17 KB vs ~6.4 KB.
- **Security:** 24 rounds improves resistance to differential and linear cryptanalysis, but does not fix the fundamental 56-bit key vulnerability.
- **Recommendation:** For academic study, 24 rounds demonstrates how additional rounds strengthen ciphers. For production use, AES-256 should be used instead of DES in any form.

Increasing the round count is a theoretically sound approach to strengthening a Feistel cipher, but in the case of DES, the limiting factor is the key size. Any successor or modification intended for real-world use must address this constraint through key expansion or migration to a modern standard.